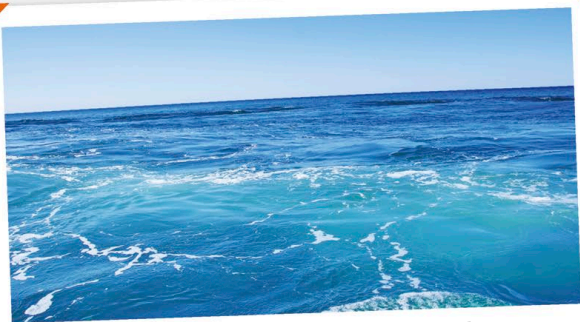
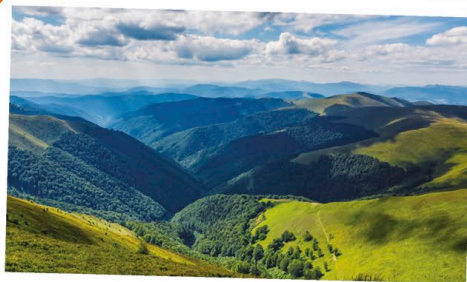




Water covers much of planet Earth

Global ocean

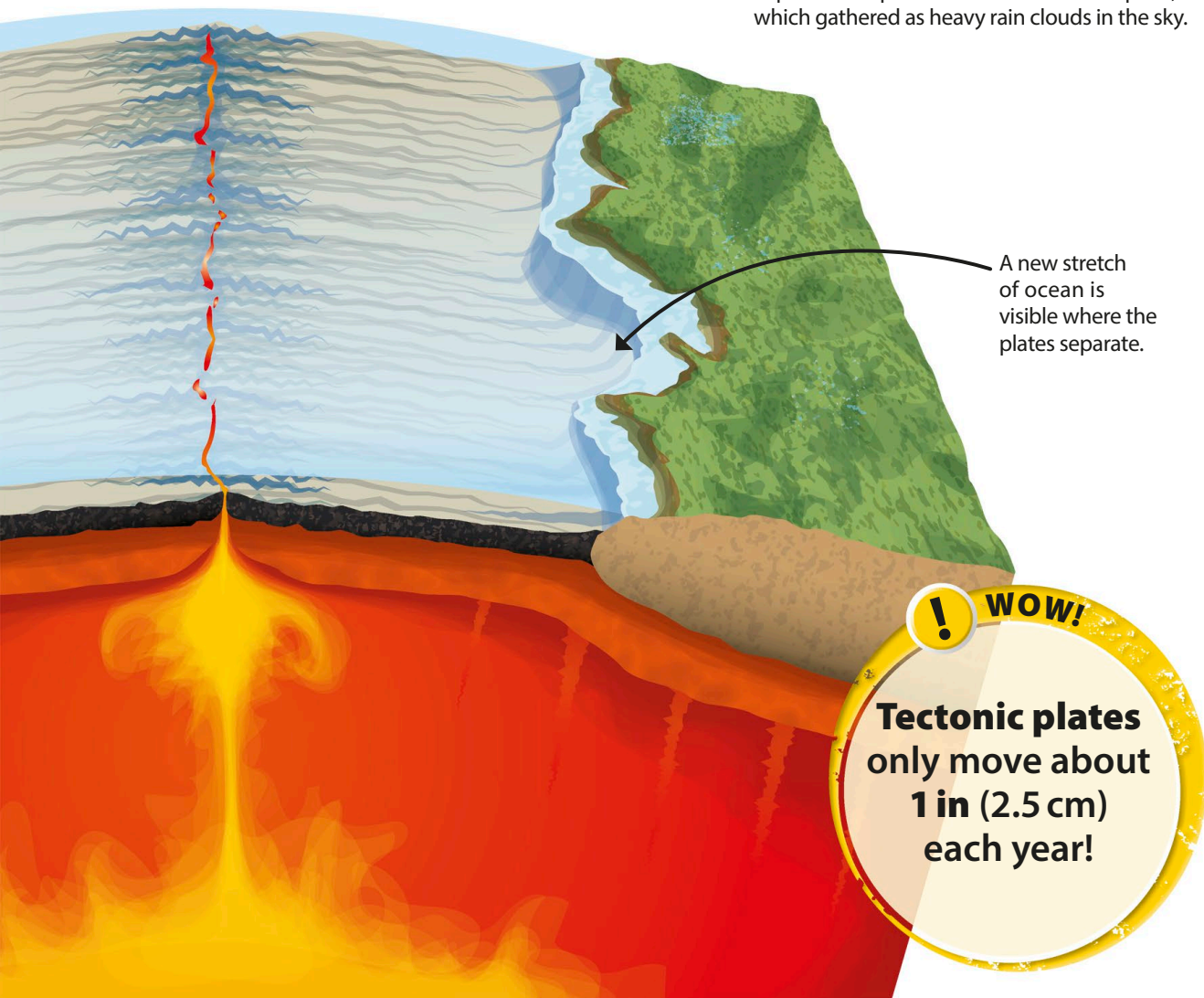
When the Earth first developed, its surface was almost entirely ocean. As the first continents formed, water in hollow areas became the five oceans we know today.



Rain clouds build up before a downpour

Water vapor

In the past, oceans were formed when hot gases were released from under the Earth's surface. These gases cooled to become water vapor. The vapor turned into water droplets, which gathered as heavy rain clouds in the sky.



A new stretch of ocean is visible where the plates separate.

! WOW!

Tectonic plates only move about 1 in (2.5 cm) each year!